

Brazil votes with Lula and Flávio Bolsonaro leading the polls

From: BBC News Mined: 2026-10-04 5 min read

Brazilians began voting on 4 October 2026 in a general election. Twelve candidates are running for president, but two familiar names lead the **opinion polls**: current president Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva and challenger Flávio Bolsonaro.

Lula represents the left-wing Workers' Party. Flávio Bolsonaro is a right-wing politician and the son of former president Jair Bolsonaro. **Left-wing and right-wing** describe different political approaches to how a country should be governed.

Four years ago, Lula narrowly defeated Jair Bolsonaro. Jair Bolsonaro is not running this time. He is under house arrest following a conviction for plotting to overturn the election result, and restrictions prevent him from posting on social media or making public statements. However, the source reports that he backs his son's campaign.

Lula and Flávio Bolsonaro are the only candidates with support reaching double figures in the polls. Surveys suggest a second round of voting, called a **run-off**, is highly likely. However, many voters were still undecided shortly before election day, so a first-round victory remains possible.

Almost 160 million Brazilians are eligible to vote. People can vote from age 16. Voting is **compulsory** for people aged 18 to 70 who can read and write, and those who do not vote face a fine. **Opinion polls** usually question only thousands of people, so the final result may differ considerably from their predictions.

Lula, who is 80, has held the presidency three times. During his first two terms, from 2003 to 2010, he was widely praised for helping millions leave poverty through a cash-support programme called Bolsa Família. His later convictions for corruption and money laundering, which he has always denied, were **annulled** in 2021.

Environmental policy is another part of his record. Some environmentalists have criticised recent actions. Lula says oil income can help fund a move towards clean energy and that he remains committed to eventually ending fossil-fuel use. His government points to satellite data suggesting Amazon **deforestation** in the first half of 2026 fell to its lowest level in a decade.

Word Treasure

opinion polls -- Surveys that measure support by asking a sample of people about their preferences.

run-off -- A second round of voting.

compulsory -- Required rather than optional.

annulled -- Officially cancelled so that a decision no longer has legal effect.

deforestation -- The clearing or removal of forests.

left-wing and right-wing -- Terms describing different political approaches to governing a country.

Break it down

The opening introduces the election date, twelve candidates and the two poll leaders. The article explains the candidates' political positions and Jair Bolsonaro's legal restrictions. It considers the likelihood of a run-off while preserving uncertainty about the outcome. It explains voting eligibility, compulsory voting and the limitations of opinion polls. The final paragraphs examine Lula's poverty programme, annulled convictions and environmental record.

Why it matters

The election will choose Brazil's president, with almost 160 million people eligible to vote. The article helps readers distinguish poll predictions from results and consider the candidates' backgrounds and records.

Test what you remember

1. How many candidates are running for president?
 - (A) Sixteen
 - (B) Two
 - (C) Twelve
 - (D) Ten
2. Which political party does Lula represent?
 - (A) An unnamed right-wing party
 - (B) The Workers' Party
 - (C) No political party
 - (D) The party of all twelve candidates
3. Why does the article say a first-round victory remains possible?
 - (A) Polls already show a final result.
 - (B) Jair Bolsonaro is running again.
 - (C) Only two people are eligible to vote.
 - (D) Many voters were still undecided shortly before election day.
4. What does the source report about Jair Bolsonaro's role in this election?
 - (A) He leads the Workers' Party.
 - (B) He backs his son's campaign.
 - (C) He is one of the twelve candidates.
 - (D) He is allowed to make public statements.
5. What happened to Lula's later convictions for corruption and money laundering?
 - (A) They were annulled in 2021.
 - (B) They were cancelled during his first term.
 - (C) They were upheld in 2003.
 - (D) They were announced on election day.
6. What does the satellite data cited by Lula's government suggest?
 - (A) All fossil-fuel use ended in 2026.
 - (B) Amazon deforestation in the first half of 2026 fell to its lowest level in a decade.
 - (C) The Amazon lost all its forests.
 - (D) Oil income stopped funding energy projects.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: D 4: B 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Undecided voters: Many voters were still undecided shortly before election day, leaving uncertainty about the outcome.
2. Some environmentalists: They have criticised recent actions connected to Lula's environmental record.
3. Lula: He says oil income can fund a move towards clean energy and maintains his commitment to eventually ending fossil-fuel use.
4. Lula's government: It points to satellite data suggesting Amazon deforestation in the first half of 2026 reached its lowest level in a decade.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):